

Name: JOHN DOE. Columbia ID: C004389328 Date of Birth: 20th June 2001. High School: WINCHESTER HIGH

Dear Marinaccio,

I greatly appreciate the careful review of my application to Columbia and the consequent decision to offer me a position on the waitlist. I understand that admission to Columbia is very competitive and I am encouraged to know that my application is still under active consideration. Since Columbia is my absolute top choice school, I am writing to reaffirm my unrelenting interest in joining Columbia's class of 2024 and provide updates on my engagements and achievements since submitting my application.

Since January, I have expanded my works in Afrofuturism, a field that explores the intersection of science fiction, technology and the future of Africa. For instance, I have added three more posts in my Afrofuturism Blog, achieving a readership of 600+ people, and exhibited two Afrofuturistic comics at the Nairobi Design Week in March. Additionally, I am working with Afro-Renaissance, a collective of award-winning Kenyan comic artists, to create a digital Afrofuturistic comic series for children whose learning has been disrupted by COVID-19. As I seek to further my Afrofuturism works, I am very exuberant about the prospect of collaborating with creatives in Columbia's Science Fiction Society and organizing more Afrofuturistic-themed events. My interactions here will uniquely position me to form valuable networks and friendships and, more importantly, advance the course of Afrofuturism globally.

Furthermore, I have advanced my engineering project, the Fish Phone, a revolutionary technology in fishing. I conducted a five-week independent research study on the influence of water alkalinity in the transmission of frequency-specific radio waves, whose results enabled me to join the Watson Startup Incubator Program. Here I will receive guidance on how to scale my project to an enterprise that will spearhead Kenya's Government infant initiatives on the Blue Economy. I am also happy to report that I was nominated as an Ashoka LeadYoung by Ashoka Changemakers, an Africa Young Leader by Teen General Assembly and a Junior Research Fellow by the New York's Academy of Sciences Junior Academy. These networks of young and global pioneers of change have demonstrated to me that no one is ever too young to positively impact his/her own community, a lesson I hope to bring to Columbia.

Currently, I am taking the *Machine Learning and Artificial Intelligence* online course from Stanford, after which I plan on developing an algorithm to optimize energy use in the smart solar microgrid installed in my Fish Phone project. Working on this two-year-long project has expanded my horizons on engineering's applicability to solving some of the greatest societal challenges, and introduced me to a new field, nanotechnology. Going forward, my mission is to pioneer and lead applications of nanotechnology in the development of smart renewable energy systems in Kenya and other developing countries. Without a doubt Rochester will propel me towards achieving this aspiration by enabling me to access training and opportunities that are unavailable in Kenya. Particularly, Columbia's Nano-Initiative and the Kluge Research Fellows which will enable me to not only contribute to Professor Matthias Preindi's research on applications of thin-film nanomaterials in energy and electronic systems but also pursue undergraduate research that contributes to Columbia's World's Project Initiatives on *Combating Household Pollution in developing countries with*

clean energy.

Each day I learn about Columbia through its students, alumni or media coverage, I become increasingly convinced me that there's no better place for me to grow and flourish than among the Columbia Lions. And thus, if admitted, I would happily matriculate for the Class of 2024. Go Lions!

NAME: GRACE

COLUMBIA ID:126373839

HIGH SCHOOL: PANGANI

DATE OF BIRTH: 15TH JULY 2004

Dear Marinaccio,

I appreciate you for taking the time to read my application. Columbia is an extremely selective school and I am happy to be included in the waitlist. If nothing else, it is a strong indicator that the admissions committee is confident that I would be a potentially good fit. I do not take this for granted. I am writing to reiterate my interest in Columbia as well as my commitment to enrol in the event that I do get admitted off the waitlist.

Columbia has, for a long time, been my top choice university. Not only will my voyage through the four years be characterized by the transformative close-knit communal learning experience embraced in the Core Curriculum, but it will also be punctuated by marvellous research, study abroad, and internship opportunities. Of particular interest to me is the study abroad program at the London School of Economics. Additionally, I aim to gain crucial insight on the functioning of global economies through a valuable international work experience through the Columbia Experience Oversees Program. I believe the aforementioned attributes will go a long way in helping me lay a solid foundation for my intended Economics major.

Other than posting new blog posts on Artsiva, programming various software systems for my clients, and reading more content on Medium since hitting the submit button on my common application, I have joined IHub Kenya, a technology driven innovation hub and hacker space. I have dedicated numerous hours to developing my entrepreneurial and networking skills within its dynamic community. Among the many (often controversial) lessons I have gleaned as a member of IHub is how to think small. By learning how to not bite off too much but rather focusing on doing few things exceptionally well, I have improved the overall calibre of my existing businesses. More importantly, I have moved beyond visualizing them as startups to setting them up as long-term businesses focused on building quality products that will have enduring social impact. To increase my knowledge, I have enrolled in edX where I am currently taking three self-paced courses: *Entrepreneurship in Emerging Economies* by Harvard, *Becoming an Entrepreneur* by MIT, and *Circular Economy: An introduction* by

Tu Delft. I am extremely excited by the prospect of further increasing my business know-how at the Columbia Entrepreneurship Design Studio where I will learn “human-centred design” which I believe will prove critical in my current and future business pursuits. Integrating this with economics, which also focuses on the behaviour of humans and how that affects resource allocation and informs decisions will place me at a better position in the world post graduation. In line with my academic and social interests are the works of Professor Jagdish N. Bhagwati, specifically his book: “*Why Growth Matters: How Economic Growth in India Reduced Poverty and the Lessons for Other Developing Countries*”. How exciting it will be to learn under him!

I understand that this information may not impact my position on the waitlist, but I felt it would be important to share it with you nonetheless. I am still extremely exuberant about the possibility of being in the midst of the brilliant minds at Columbia, spending time with my newly found potpourri of friends cheering the Lions against Fordham for the Liberty cup at the Robert K. Kraft Field at Lawrence A. Wien Stadium, and taking in all that Columbia’s rich historical side has to offer.

Thank you for your time and consideration.

Yours Sincerely,

Swaib Ouma Okita,

2018 Equity Leadership Program Scholar.

This past weekend, I got the opportunity to spend some time up in New Haven for the Yale University Model United Nations Conference (YMUN), serving as part of the United Nations International Strategy for Disaster Reduction Committee (UNISDR) and debating rising sea levels and volcanic eruptions. Speaking with current Yale students made me realize more than ever before that I was with my people—warm, incredibly funny, artistic in their own way, and unabashedly inquisitive. This weekend, I was where I belong.

I would also like to take this time to briefly tell the admissions department about a few things that have happened since I submitted my Early Action application. First, I wrote, illustrated, and published a children’s book centered around gender inclusivity in STEM fields, with all proceeds going towards supporting curriculum development and outreach for the Stereotype Project, an organization I’ve been running for the past four years that focuses on combating stereotypes through art. I’ve attached PDF copies of my book, Mika and the Microscope, along with some other information, but you should be receiving a copy in the mail soon. I very much believe the magic of reading is magnified when the book is in its physical form

(and I think my brother and sister, 5 and 9, would definitely agree).